

SECTION 1: Spontaneous Language Sampling (SLS) Protocol

Gathering a spontaneous, unprompted language sample is the clinical gold standard for assessing Gestalt Language Processors (GLPs) within the Natural Language Acquisition (NLA) framework (Blanc, 2012; Lee, 1974). Conventional standardized tests fail to accurately evaluate receptive or expressive language in early-stage GLPs because they rely on direct questioning, compliance-based carrier prompts, and forced performance tasks. Standardized tasks cause cognitive fatigue and motor dysregulation, causing GLPs to resort to automatic, unanalyzed gestalts rather than demonstrating their true self-generated language competence (Prizant, 1983; Wetherby & Prizant, 1992).

- **1. Sampling Duration & Quantity Minimums:** Elicit a representative sample containing a minimum of **12 continuous minutes** or **50+ spontaneous, consecutive utterances** (Blanc, 2012; Chapter 19 Revised, 2024).
- **2. Sensory & Motor Regulation Prerequisite:** Collaborate directly with an Occupational Therapist (OT) prior to language sampling. Ensure physical, vestibular (e.g., swinging, spinning), and proprioceptive inputs (e.g., crash pads, heavy work) are available. A dysregulated nervous system cannot access higher-level linguistic formulation (Ayres, 1972; Taylor & Trott, 1991).
- **3. Presume Competence & Eliminate Prompting:** Completely eliminate direct WH- questions, commands, and carrier prompts (e.g., 'Say...', 'I want...'). Interrogative pressure places GLPs in 'question/answer mode,' halting natural spontaneous speech flow (Zachos & Blanc, 2022).
- **4. Verbatim Transcription with Conversational Partner Context:** Transcribe all child utterances verbatim, including non-verbal movements (echopraxia), intonational pitch contours of unintelligible 'jargon,' and immediate partner turns to preserve exact pragmatic context (Blanc, 2012).
- **5. Receptive Testing Warning:** Receptive vocabulary testing (e.g., PPVT) is inappropriate until a child reaches Stage 4 novel grammar. Early-stage GLPs process words as holistic units, not 1:1 referential labels (Zachos, 2021).

SECTION 2: NLA Stage Classification Matrix (Stages 0 – 6)

Stage	NLA Stage Name	Linguistic Feature & Diagnostic Criteria	Spontaneous Exemplar
Stage 0	Taught / Prompted Language	Directly taught, drilled, or compliance-based carrier phrases (e.g., ABA targets). Scored 0 to protect spontaneous baseline metrics (Blanc, 2012; 2024).	'I want chips' (Prompted carrier)
Stage 1	Whole Gestalts (Delayed Echolalia)	Naturally acquired multi-word chunks, media scripts, or 'stuck' single words carrying a whole situational meaning. Unanalyzed units (Peters, 1983; Prizant, 1983).	'To infinity and beyond!' (Means: Let's play!)
Stage 2	Mitigations (Mix & Match)	Trimming down long gestalts, recombining partial gestalts, or plug-and-play frame-and-slot swaps (Peters, 1983; Blanc, 2012).	'Let's get + some more?' (Partial recombine)
Stage 3	Freed Words (Isolation & Combos)	Isolating referential single words (1:1 meaning with pointing/gaze) and flexible 2-word combinations with no verbs or grammar (Blanc, 2012).	'Mama ball' 'Blue ball'
Stage 4	Beginning Grammar (Novel Generation)	Combining freed words into original pre-sentences. Characterized by typical developmental grammar errors (DST & DSS Levels 1–3; Lee, 1974).	'Him gots ball' 'Monster goed under'
Stage 5/6	Advanced Syntax (Complex Grammar)	Mature grammar, complex verb tenses, conjunctions, and conversational systems (DSS Levels 4–8; Lee, 1974).	'I'm reading a book myself next time.'

SECTION 3: The Gestalt Check-In for Linguistic Variety & Target Selection

A critical clinical prerequisite exists in NLA: before a child is ready to transition support from Stage 1 whole gestalts to Stage 2 mitigations, they must possess a robust variety of gestalts across multiple communicative functions (Blanc, 2012; Zachos, 2021). If a child uses many gestalts but only for 'Commenting,' their expressive repertoire is too narrow to support natural mitigation. Clinicians must map active gestalts across the 10 core NLA communicative categories:

Communicative Function	NLA Definition & Pragmatic Purpose	Easily Mitigated Spontaneous Models
1. Commenting	Sharing attention or making observations about immediate play/environment (Blanc, 2012).	<i>'That's a big one!'</i> , <i>'It's stuck.'</i> , <i>'Check it out!'</i>
2. Requesting Help	Securing adult assistance for physical, sensory, or motor planning tasks (Zachos, 2021).	<i>'How 'bout some help?'</i> , <i>'Come on help!'</i> , <i>'Help me.'</i>
3. Protests & Denial	Refusing unwanted activities or self-advocating against dysregulating states (Dorsey, 2021).	<i>'I don't like it.'</i> , <i>'Stop doing that.'</i> , <i>'Don't touch it.'</i>
4. Transitions	Signaling readiness to end an activity or move to a new environment (Zachos, 2021).	<i>'Time for bath.'</i> , <i>'What's next?'</i> , <i>'Wanna do something different.'</i>
5. Shared Joy & Humor	Expressing delight, shared amusement, or engaging in vocal play with partners (Blanc, 2012).	<i>'We did it!'</i> , <i>'That's so funny!'</i> , <i>'Look at it go!'</i>
6. Initiating Play	Inviting peers or adults into a shared activity or parallel interaction (Zachos, 2021).	<i>'Let's play together.'</i> , <i>'Wanna join?'</i> , <i>'I'd like a turn.'</i>
7. Self-Advocacy	Expressing sensory overstimulation, emotional needs, or requesting space (Dorsey, 2021).	<i>'That's too noisy.'</i> , <i>'Need a quiet spot.'</i> , <i>'I'm overwhelmed.'</i>
8. Sensory-Motor	Verbalizing during vestibular, proprioceptive, or gross motor regulation play (Ayres, 1972).	<i>'Gotta jump high!'</i> , <i>'Time to spin.'</i> , <i>'Up, up and away!'</i>
9. Recurrence	Requesting the continuation or repetition of a favored sensory experience (Blanc, 2012).	<i>'Let's do it again!'</i> , <i>'How 'bout some more?'</i> , <i>'Keep going!'</i>
10. New Experiences	Acknowledging unfamiliar environments, novel toys, or schedule changes (Zachos, 2021).	<i>'That's brand new!'</i> , <i>'Look at this one.'</i> , <i>'What happened?'</i>

SECTION 4: The 'No-You' Perspective-Shift Modeling Cheat Sheet

The Clinical Rule: Stage 1 and Stage 2 GLPs store spoken models verbatim as holistic chunks. If an adult asks *'Do you want juice?'*, the child stores that exact chunk to mean *'I want juice'*, causing chronic pronoun reversal (saying 'you' instead of 'I'). Clinicians must strictly model language from the child's perspective (first-person **'I'm...'**) or a joint perspective (**'Let's...'**, **'We gotta...'**) so that when echoed, the script is grammatically functional (Blanc, 2012; Peters, 1983).

Context Scenario	Adult Question to AVOID	ChildLed Perspective-Shift Model	Target Frame
Leaving room / PE	<i>'Are you ready to go?'</i>	'Let's go outside!' or 'Time to run!'	Joint / Time to...
Student needs help	<i>'Do you need help?'</i>	'Gotta find a way.' or 'We need help.'	Gotta... / We...
Sensory / Snack play	<i>'Is it yummy?'</i>	'That's so yummy!' or 'I like this snack.'	That's... / I'm...
Desk work transition	<i>'Sit in your chair.'</i>	'Time for desk.' or 'How 'bout chairs?'	Time for... / How 'bout...

SECTION 5: Advanced Scoring Case Studies & Chapter 19 Edge Case Guide

Mastering NLA language sample scoring requires analyzing complex edge cases where unanalyzed carryover chunks, single-word gestalts, and contractions overlap. Analyze these four clinical case studies grounded in Marge Blanc's **Revised 2024 Chapter 19 Scoring Guidelines**:

Case Study 1: Differentiating Stage 1 Single-Word Gestalts from Stage 3 Freed Words

- *The Clinical Scenario*: During water play, a 5-year-old child points to a plastic fish and says 'Fish'. An untrained clinician might score this as an isolated Stage 3 referential word and attempt to expand it to 'blue fish'.
- *The Clinical Investigation*: NLA detective work reveals that 'Fish' was acquired during a highly emotional aquarium vacation trip. Every time the child says 'Fish', they speak it with a hyper-specific descending pitch contour mimicking their father's voice, using it whenever they are near water (e.g., bath, pool, rain) (Zachos, 2021).
- *The Scoring Verdict*: Classified as a **Stage 1 Single-Word Gestalt**. It is an unanalyzed, intonationally-defined unit carrying a whole situational experience (the aquarium trip) rather than a 1:1 referential label (Blanc, 2012; 2024). The child cannot combine this word flexibly with other nouns or adjectives without regard to word order.

Case Study 2: The Chapter 19 'Mini-Chunk' Rule (Eliminating Split/Half-Scores)

- *The Clinical Scenario*: A child self-generates: 'There's a monster falled over'.
- *The Clinical Investigation*: Historical NLA scoring (pre-2022) assigned split-scores or half-points (e.g., scoring 2/4) when an utterance contained a blend of mitigation and grammar. However, Marge Blanc's **Revised 2024 Chapter 19 guidelines** officially eliminated all half-scores to reflect modern linguistic complexity (Blanc, 2024).
- *The Scoring Verdict*: Classified fully as a **Stage 4 Beginning Grammar** utterance. The clinician scores the highest spontaneous stage achieved (Stage 4) and logs a Mini-Chunk Flag for 'There's a monster'. This alerts the clinical team that 'There's a monster' remains un-unglued as a floating Stage 2 chunk carried over into original grammar.

Case Study 3: The Contraction Parsing Rule (Auxiliary/Copula Chunks)

- *The Clinical Scenario*: A child says 'It's breaking' and 'Let's open it'.
- *The Clinical Investigation*: True Stage 3 and early Stage 4 self-generations do not contain contractions (e.g., *it's*, *let's*, *there's*, *gotta*) because contractions require isolating, freeing, and recombining auxiliary/copula verbs—a sophisticated Stage 4+ skill (Blanc, 2012; Lee, 1974).
- *The Scoring Verdict*: Classified as **Stage 2 Mitigations** (Frame-and-Slot blocks where 'It's' and 'Let's' function as unanalyzed starter frames). They are **not** scored as Stage 4 original grammar unless the child demonstrates freed referential verb play across their sample (Blanc, 2024).

Case Study 4: Sensory-Emotional Dysregulation Reversion Flag

- *The Clinical Scenario*: A child who operates primarily at Stage 4 (65% novel grammar) experiences a loud sensory overload during fire drill practice and repeats 'Everybody back to the clubhouse!' continuously for 10 minutes.
- *The Clinical Investigation*: Formulating novel Stage 4 grammar is cognitively taxing and slow to retrieve during high arousal. GLPs naturally revert to automatic Stage 1 gestalts for nervous system grounding and self-soothing (Blanc, 2012; Prizant, 1983).
- *The Scoring Verdict*: Scored as Stage 1 with a Regulation Context Reversion tag. This reversion must **not** be interpreted as developmental regression or loss of academic skill (Dorsey, 2021; Zachos, 2021).

SECTION 6: Mathematical Baseline Analysis & Threshold Formulas

To determine which stage a GLP is developmentally 'living in' and direct clinical goals, clinicians transcribe a 50+ utterance sample, tally total occurrences at each NLA stage, and calculate mathematical percentages (Blanc, 2012):

Linguistic Metric	Baseline Formula & Mathematical Threshold	Clinical Directives & Action
50% Main Stage Threshold	$(\text{Stage X Utterances} / \text{Total Scored}) \geq 50\%$	Defines the stage where the child currently 'lives' developmentally. Clinical targets must focus on supporting language in Stage X (Blanc, 2012; 2024).
80% Operating Threshold	$(\text{Stage X Utterances} / \text{Total Scored}) \geq 80\%$	Indicates the child is operating almost exclusively within Stage X. Target linguistic variety across all 10 communicative functions before moving forward (Zachos, 2021).
Mixed NLA Profile	No single stage holds $\geq 50\%$	The child actively uses processes across multiple stages. The highest active stage with significant representation indicates their developmental trajectory direction (Blanc, 2012).

SECTION 7: Neurodiversity-Affirming Goal Template Bank

- **Foundational Trust & Regulation Goal:** Given sensory-motor supports of the child's choosing (e.g., vestibular swing, heavy work), CHILD will participate in shared, child-led special interest play with an adult partner for 15 minutes, maintaining emotional regulation without demands (Taylor & Trott, 1991; Cari Ebert & Zachos, 2022).
- **Stage 1 Linguistic Variety Goal:** Given child-led play and adult declarative modeling without expectation, CHILD will spontaneously acquire and produce 5 new mitigable gestalts across at least 3 distinct communicative categories (e.g., Transitions, Protests, Help) as measured by quarterly language sample logs (Zachos, 2021).
- **Stage 2 Mitigation Goal:** Provided an environment supporting self-regulation, CHILD will spontaneously produce mitigations (trimming down or mix-and-matching partial gestalts), increasing Stage 2 NLA utterances to 20% within a 50-utterance spontaneous language sample (Blanc, 2012).
- **Stage 3 Isolation & Combination Goal:** During referential play activities of the child's choosing, CHILD will spontaneously isolate freed single words from former gestalts and produce 5 original 2-word combinations (noun+noun, adjective+noun) with no regard to word order and no verbs (Blanc, 2012; 2024).
- **Stage 4 Beginning Grammar Goal:** Provided vestibular/proprioceptive supports during child-led interactions, CHILD will self-generate 10 original pre-sentence utterances containing beginning grammar (DSS Levels 1–3) as evaluated by an NLA-trained clinician (Lee, 1974; Blanc, 2012).

SECTION 8: Clinical SOAP Note Documentation Exemplar

CLINICAL SESSION SOAP NOTE EXEMPLAR (ChildLed™ Platform Documentation)

S (Subjective): Client arrived with high positive affect. Parent reported child experienced a dysregulating transition change at school earlier but was eager for play. Parent confirmed logging two new home-based Stage 1 delayed echolalic phrases from 'Encanto' on the ChildLed app.

O (Objective): Elicited a 15-minute child-led spontaneous language sample (54 total utterances) during train set and magnetic tile play. OT-recommended sensory swing input was integrated prior to play to support motor regulation. No direct questions or verbal prompts were used.

Quantitative Baseline Percentages: Stage 1 = 15% (8/54), Stage 2 = 55% (30/54), Stage 3 = 20% (11/54), Stage 4 = 10% (5/54). Client meets the **50% Main Stage Threshold for Stage 2 Mitigations**.

Qualitative Observations: Client spontaneously mitigated 'Let's go play' + 'Grandma's house' into 'Let's go Grandma's house'. One Stage 2 mini-chunk ('There's a') was noted within a Stage 4 self-generation ('There's a train falled over').

A (Assessment): Client continues to make steady progress through Stage 2 mitigation, demonstrating rich linguistic variety across Commenting, Help, and Transitions. Demonstrates emerging Stage 3 freed words and Stage 4 beginning grammar during well-regulated sensory play.

P (Plan): Continue child-led play therapy 2x/week for 45 minutes. Model easily mitigable Stage 2 starter frames ('It's...', 'How 'bout...') and explore Stage 3 referential wordplay with noun+noun combinations. Maintain interdisciplinary OT sensory consultation.

SECTION 9: Professional & Academic References

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